

1.2 Comparative commentary

Paper 1 Reading · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Compare how two texts construct meanings for different audiences and purposes, not just list devices separately. Analyse how lexis, syntax, imagery, cohesion and structure position the reader. Embed short evidence, explain effects cautiously and connect differences to genre and context.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

An emergency notice's imperatives ("Leave now") create urgency, while a reflective diary's past tense and sensory detail may build hindsight; comparison ties each choice to audience.

Original practice stimulus

Text A, a notice on the hall door: "Please leave the hall immediately by the east exit. Staff will direct you to the assembly point beside the library. Do not return for your belongings. We will announce when it is safe to re-enter." The notice is printed in large black type and organised as four short sentences. Text B, a diary entry written that evening: "The hall emptied in less than a minute, yet the echo of footsteps stayed with me. I remember the chair scraping across the floor, then the strange calm of the courtyard. Nobody seemed to know what had happened. Even now, I look toward the east exit when the room falls quiet."

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Text A: "Please leave the hall immediately by the east exit." Text B: "The hall emptied, but the echo of footsteps stayed with me." Compare how their language creates different responses.

[25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong comparison links A's polite imperative, location detail and immediate time frame to safety; B's personification of echo, first-person viewpoint and retrospective past tense to memory. Develop an argument about audience, not a catalogue of labels.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: English Language 9093, 2024–2026.
<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/635901-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.